# WALKING THE TALK



**SCOUTING FOR VOTES** TDP leader Nara Lokesh on his padayatra

With his 'Yuva Galam' or Voice of Youth yatra, 40-year-old Nara Lokesh, national general secretary of the Telugu Desam Party and son of the party supremo Chandrababu Naidu, is hoping to do one better than anyone else, including his father. He will be walking 4,000 kilometres, more than the late Congress chief minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy did in the early 2000s and his son Jagan reprised during his 'Praja Sankalpa Yatra' before the 2019 assembly polls.

The intent is to woo the voters, with promises that concern the entire state as well as local issues. The walkathon is also intended as a sort of makeover for Lokesh, long dismissed as another entitled dynast who could not even converse in Telugu and who has little of the shrewdness of his father. Detractors—both within the TDP and outside—portrayed him as inept and even body-shamed him. Naidu's decision to induct him into the state cabinet via the Legislative Council without winning a direct election did not go down well either.

Weighed down by all the flak between 2014 and 2019, Lokesh, a former minister, has now worked on his oratory. Moreover, instead of staying confined to backroom tasks due to his deficient Telugu, Lokesh is now listening to people's problems and often offering solution then and there. He has been walking 13.5 km a day on an average, and had visited 1,297 villages in 195 mandals and received 2,895 petitions from the people by the time he completed half the 4,000-km trek at Kothapalli village near Kavali in Nellore district on July 11. "Let us dedicate ourselves to rebuilding the sunrise state of Andhra Pradesh by bringing the TDP back to power" is his fervent appeal at the whistle-stop meetings on the trek.

By building a strong people connect, Lokesh is hoping to present the TDP as a credible alternative and trigger a new wave of support for the party. Being young himself, he also attempts to reach out to the youth during his stops. "I take the responsibility to create new job opportunities for the youth both in the public and private sectors," he has asserted several times. He is also promising a monthly allowance of Rs 3,000 for jobless youth.

Those who have joined him on the march include three MLAs suspended by the YSRCP—Anam Ramnarayana Reddy, Kotamreddy Sridhar Reddy and Mekapati Chandrasekhar Reddy. Observers mostly see it as a welcome development for the TDP but do admit that getting people from the YSRCP into the yellow party's fold may prove counter-productive.

His actions are shoring up his image on social media as well. #YuvaGalamPadayatra clocked more than a million tweets at the halfway point of his trek. Related hashtags, #YuvaGalam and #YuvaGalamLokesh, together clocked another one million tweets. He may not fill his father's shoes yet, but Lokesh is sure hitting his stride.

tal Jagan presumes will accrue on account of his welfare politics, and hopes Yuva Galam will better its chances. "Welfare measures alone are inadequate to ensure votes," says former TDP minister S. Chandramohan Reddy, who is optimistic about his party's comeback. "Anti-incumbency has peaked and there is widespread disillusionment with the sharp increase in prices, especially of sand, gravel and liquor." According to the TDP's calculations, an electoral triumph can be a possibility with the JSP's cooperation, while an alliance with the BJP could enhance prospects.

However, with the likes of Ram Madhav and N. Kiran Kumar Reddy, the last Congress chief minister of united Andhra Pradesh, in the BJP, the prospects of a joint contest seem bleak unless Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shah decide so. Party insiders say these leaders have been against the TDP and believe that a triangular contest will only help the YSRCP. The BJP perhaps even needs Jagan Reddy. "The present stoic silence of the BJP is understandable given its move on the UCC and the need to seek Jagan Reddy's support in Parliament," says political analyst V. Chandramouliswar Rao.

The YSRCP is certainly no pushover. "It is confident of its welfare plank as it looks to win a second term," says E. Venkatesu of the department of political science, University of Hyderabad. However, he does add some caveats. "The YSRCP vote share may see a decline due to several factors—unemployment, failure to keep the Navaratnalu (a set of nine welfare schemes) promises, including prohibition, and the growing discontent among the backward classes and the Kapus (the JSP cohort)."

But this does not mean it is advantage TDP. Naidu may salvage the TDP from a virtual collapse in 2024, but the prospects of coming to power are bleak, according to political commentator D. Subramanyam Reddy. "The poor consider Jagan their saviour who works determinedly to emancipate them from poverty. This makes it difficult to weaken his political base," he says. In fact, if the YSRCP's main rivals do not come together, there could be fresh challenges for the TDP after the election. A tactful Purandeswari may steer a drift from the TDP to the BJP, marking the end of the road for Naidu. ■